

CAPA (Corrective and Preventive Action)

Preparing and executing a CAPA (Corrective and Preventive Action) involves a systematic, 7-step quality management methodology. Its core purpose is to investigate non-conformances, identify root causes, implement targeted solutions to prevent recurrence (Corrective) and occurrence (Preventive), and thoroughly verify effectiveness.

The 7-Step CAPA Process

1. Identification

- **Goal:** Document the actual or potential non-conformance.
- **Actions:** Log the issue, record evidence, and note the date, location, and potential impact on operations or product safety.

2. Evaluation & Risk Assessment

- **Goal:** Determine the severity and urgency of the issue.
- **Actions:** Assess the impact on customers, regulations, and costs. Decide whether a full, formal CAPA is required or if a simple "correction" will suffice.

3. Investigation & Data Collection

- **Goal:** Gather facts rather than relying on assumptions.
- **Actions:** Assemble a cross-functional team (e.g., Quality Assurance, Engineering, Operations) to collect all relevant data, historical logs, and process mappings.

4. Root Cause Analysis (RCA)

- **Goal:** Discover the underlying systemic cause, not just the symptom.
- **Actions:** Utilize established problem-solving frameworks such as the Five Whys or Fishbone (Ishikawa) diagrams.

5. Action Plan Development

- **Goal:** Create a structured mitigation plan.
- **Actions:** Formulate specific **Corrective Actions** (to fix current issues and stop recurrence) and **Preventive Actions** (to prevent similar potential issues elsewhere). Assign owners and deadlines to each step.

6. Implementation & Documentation

- **Goal:** Execute the plan.
- **Actions:** Carry out the predefined steps across the organization. Ensure every action is strictly documented for traceability and audit readiness.

7. Verification & Effectiveness Check

- **Goal:** Prove the solution actually worked.

- **Actions:** Monitor the affected process over a designated period to ensure the error does not return. Document final closure once effectiveness is confirmed.
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Best Practices for Execution

- **Don't Rush the RCA:** The most common CAPA Mistake is skipping straight to the solution without finding the true root cause.
- **Move Beyond "Human Error":** If a human error occurs, investigate *why* the system or process allowed the error to happen in the first place.
- **Integrate with Risk:** Align your actions dynamically with broader Quality Management Systems to foster continuous improvement.